

“Playing the Game”: Reputation in Moonsea Rising

D&D characters are exceptional. Heroic even. But it takes more than that to Play the Game. You must cultivate alliances, undermine your enemies, and rally the people to your cause. These additional Reputation rules try to provide mechanics for that process

If your party achieves success, each PC will likely start to gain a reputation: influence you can use to further your goals. The details of reputation may differ from PC to PC, especially for those trying to keep a low profile, but this is a dynamic system designed to enable PCs to impact the world around them. Here’s how it works.

You must decide what you want your character to be “known for” - i.e., how you want him to be perceived by the larger community (you can define this community in a variety of ways). There are six types of reputation traits that you can cultivate, with each trait being a set of closely related qualities that people associate with greatness: (1) Charm (beauty/grace/likability); (2) Smarts (brains/strategy/intelligence/knowledge); (3) Morals (piety/altruism/sacrifice/goodness/dedication to “the cause”); (4) Judgment (wisdom/savvy/canniness/shrewdness); (5) Cleverness (subterfuge/discretion/secretiveness); and (6) Courage (bravery/strength/intimidation/resilience).

You all start the second chapter with two ranks, one each in two of these traits, some ranks dictated by ability scores and others based on the deeds you performed that you felt were most representative of how you want your character to be seen. The ranks were influenced by choices you made in the game and in the Slack channel.

From here on out, whenever your character has an opportunity to engage in reputational encounters (think of these as social rounds, but they last a day or more and don’t only happen in one place or between only two people), you can either **use your reputation** or **increase your reputation**.

You increase your reputation by performing a task related to that facet of your reputation you wish to enhance. You must attempt a skill check associated with that task, with a **DC equal to 14 + the rank you are trying to achieve**. For example, the DC is 17 if you are trying to hit Rank 3 ($14+3=17$), but 24 if you are trying to reach rank 10 ($14+10=24$). If you succeed at the check, your rank in that trait increases by 1.

Reputation DCs

Rank	DC to Gain
1	15
2	16
3	17
4	18
5	19
6	20
7	21
8	22
9	23
10	24

Here are some examples of tasks you can perform during a reputation round to increase your rank in a reputational trait.

Arrange a Secret Meeting (Traits: Charm or Cleverness)

You arrange a clandestine meeting between individuals who can't or won't speak openly.
Associated Skill: Persuasion; Deception; Sleight of Hand.

Bask in Glory (Courage)

You make sure that everyone knows about your own reputational achievements.
Associated Skill: Performance; Persuasion.

Demonstrate Might (Courage)

You show off your strength to impressed onlookers.
Associated Skill: Strength Save.

Drive Legislation (Charm, Smarts, Morals, Cleverness)

You take a prominent role in drafting or promoting legislation or another form of governmental policy.
Associated Skill: Performance (Charm); History (Smarts); Insight/Religion (Morals), Deception/Persuasion (Cleverness).

Give a Lecture/Speech (Smarts or Morals)

Whether you're delivering an academic lecture or a religious sermon, you draw a crowd to listen as you share your expertise.
Associated Skill: History/Arcana/Religion/Nature (Smarts); Performance (Charm).

Organize a Party (Charm)

You put together a popular social event that is the talk of the town.
Associated Skill: Performance; Persuasion.

Organize a Protest (Courage or Morals)

You gather people to protest loathsome policies, either through rhetoric or doggedness.
Associated Skill: Wisdom Save (Courage); Persuasion; Performance; Religion [if the protest involves a question of theology or doctrine]; Nature [an environmental protest, for example]Smarta(Morals)

Perform Charitable Acts (Morals)

You spend your time or money tending to those most in need of aid.
Associated Skill: Medicine.

Sabotage Opponent (Smarts or Cleverness)

You cunningly set one of your opponents up for a fall, perhaps causing one of his shameful secrets to go public.
Associated Skill: History (local or nobility), as appropriate to the opponent (Smarts); Sleight of Hand/Stealth/Deception (Cleverness).

Max ranks in any one trait equals your PC level. Max ranks in the aggregate, across all traits equals twice PC level. For example, assume Jareth is a 5th level PC with 5 ranks in Courage. Jareth cannot raise his ranks in Courage any higher until he reaches 6th level. Further, let's assume Jareth also has 2 ranks in Smarts and 3 ranks in Judgment. He has maxed out the ranks he can acquire as a 5th level character because he has a total of 10 ranks (5 Courage + 2 Smarts + 3 Judgment).

As you earn additional ranks in a given type of reputational trait, you can do more with it.

Trait Ranks	Benefits
1	Agents
2	Basic Ops
3	Skill Bonus (advantage)
4	Admirers (indifferent)
5	Bonus Feat
6	Advanced Ops
7	Skill Bonus (+2)
8	Admirers (unfriendly)
9	Friend in High Places
10	Master of Ops

Agents: You get a number of agents equal to twice your aggregate number of ranks across all traits. So, if you have Charm 2 and Morals 2, then you get 8 agents. These are people who flock to you, or follow you, or who share your dedication to “the cause” or whom you have charmed or tricked into doing your will.

Basic Ops: If you have *at least 2 ranks*, you can send your agents on basic operations: gather intelligence, deliver messages, etc. Whatever skill checks are associated with the task you send them to perform gain a bonus of +1 per agent you send. If you send four agents to gather intel, their investigation checks get a +4. I want you to have maximum flexibility here. You can literally try to accomplish 4 different things in 1 reputation round if you are willing to split up your agents, or you can have a much greater chance of success on one important task. That said, you can only *initiate* one operation per reputation round (more on that below).

Skill Bonus: When you get 3 ranks in a trait, you may make one skill check per reputation round with advantage. When you reach 7 ranks in a trait, you may also add +2 to one reputation roll per round.

Admirers: Your reputation has earned you fans and sympathetic souls. Once per reputation round, you can leverage your reputation to improve the starting attitude of one NPC with an attitude of indifferent or friendly. You can increase the NPC's attitude by one step as long as you have at least 4 Ranks in a trait related to that NPC. When you get 8 Ranks in a trait, you can also

use this ability to improve the attitude of NPCs whose starting attitude is unfriendly. This is different from attempting to influence an NPC in a social encounter. Instead, this represents the NPC having heard about you and revising his or her opinion in light of the new information. This influence mechanic is limited by the trait involved; that is, some reputations only work on certain kinds of people. For example, my dad would not give two shits about your reputation for Morals or Judgment, but he would be deeply swayed by your reputation for Courage or Smarts.

Here are examples (not exhaustive) for each trait. Charm: Artists, merchants, nobles. Smarts: Academics, arcane spellcasters, instructors. Courage: Athletes, guards, soldiers. Morals: Clergy of good deities, healers, philanthropists. Judgment: judges, nobles, druids, philosophers. Cleverness: Criminals, politicians. And, of course, any NPC that has a special affinity for the trait involved.

Bonus Feat: Once you get to 5 ranks in a given trait, you gain the reputation feat associated with that trait from the DM's list. If you have 5 ranks in more than one reputational trait, you can select one feat from among the feats you've unlocked, and can change your choice each time you achieve your 5th rank in a new trait. The feats available are: Charm - Actor; Smarts: Keen Mind; Courage: Resilient; Morals - Healer; Judgment - Lucky; Cleverness - Mobile.

Advanced Ops: Once you at least 6 Ranks in a trait, you can send agents on advanced operations related to that trait. Advanced operations can be far more complex and dangerous than basic operations.

Friends in High Places: Once you have 9 ranks in a given trait, your network of contacts has grown to include a highly placed spellcaster. You may leverage your alliance to gain access to spellcasting services. If you succeed at an Operation check ($DC = 15 + \text{spell level}$), you can arrange for up to 750 gp worth of spellcasting services to be used at any time before the beginning of the next reputation round as long as you would reasonably have access to an NPC spellcaster. The most obvious example is to prepare for the worst by arranging for your highly-placed ally to cast raise dead (in this case, it is assumed your agents arrange for your resurrection on your behalf). You must also pay for any foci or expensive material components used.

Master of Ops: At 10 ranks, you are twice as effective: You get an additional reputation round in addition to the one you've just taken.

OPERATIONS

Instead of using the reputation round to increase your reputation, you can send your agents to perform an operation on your behalf. You can **initiate** only one operation per phase. You must decide which operation you intend to perform at the start of the reputation round. An operation check determines success - d20 roll with a bonus equal to the number of agents you send on the

mission with the DC set by the specific operation. You must choose how many agents to send before the roll, up to a maximum of the number of ranks you have in the relevant trait.

Example. Jareth wants to know more about the town constable and he has two ranks in Charm, so he decides to run a basic operation during the next reputation round in order to do so. His two ranks in Charm give him two agents he can use to help him with this operation. His two “agents” are a couple of comely females he has charmed into helping him. Maybe he mentioned that he wonders what the deal is with that constable, or maybe he was more explicit and told them he would do just about *anything* to get more gossip on the constable. For whatever reason, these ladies are eager to help Jareth. They spend time at the local pub flirting with patrons and asking collecting gossip about the constable every once in a while. Jareth makes his operations check by rolling a d20 and adding +2. He rolls a 14, which gives him a result of 16 (+2 for the two agents). In this case, the DC is rolling, which means the higher his roll, the more information he gathers. With a 16, Jareth learns that the constable is terrible at his job, is easily bribed, and cannot see very well at night.

You might ask why Jareth would use a reputation round to accomplish this task, rather than simply going to the pub and making an Investigation check. This is especially true if Jareth has a high Investigation bonus (say, a +5 in investigation rather than the measly +2 his agents give him as part of a reputation check). But there are several advantages to using an operation. First, this is something that will not be traced back to Jareth, as he is not the one doing the asking. Second, it is possible that his agents can go somewhere he cannot (for example, guards providing info on secure location or government functionaries providing info on the details of a private meeting). Lastly, operations are such that they can be accomplished by that individual character, operating independently with his own sphere of influence, separate from wherever the party happens to be at this moment. As a practical matter, this relieves some of the tension for using D&D, whose rules are geared towards combat and individual encounters/scenes, to engage a story of influence and intrigue.

Operations always fail on a roll of 1 and always succeed on a natural 20.

Persistent Operations: While most operations conclude at the end of a reputation round, persistent operations begin the first time you succeed at the DC 17 Operation check for that operation and continue until you call back your agents. You can maintain only one type of persistent operation at a time, and you must send at least five agents; these agents are not available for your other operations until the persistent operation ends. Persistent operations must generally be focused on one location (at the DM’s discretion, though generally limited to one town or a large neighborhood in a city); you can maintain the same persistent operation in as many locations as you has enough agents to support.

Risky Operations: Some operations are dangerous to agents’ safety or morale. If you fail a risky operation’s check by 5 or more, or if you rolls a natural 1 on the check, you lose all of the agents

you sent on the mission. These losses could represent the agents' imprisonment, their death, or their abandonment of your cause.

Basic Operations:

Filter Rumors (Smarts/Morals/Cleverness): Under your direction, your agents are skilled at separating fact from fiction. Once before the next reputation round, after you receive the results of an Investigation check to gather information, you can ask the DM to roll a secret Operation check, using the number of agents you sent on this operation for its bonus. If the check results in a success, the DM tells you whether the information gathered is mostly true, has elements of truth, or is mostly false. If the check fails, the DM tells you that the information gathered is mostly true (regardless of its actual veracity). The Operation check DC is generally 15, but if someone is actively spreading false information, the DC increases to 10 + the CR of the rumormonger (maximum 20).

Gather Information (Charm/Cleverness/Smarts): Your agents listen to the local gossip and ask pointed questions. Once before the next reputation round, you can use the result of your Operation check in place of the normal Investigation check when gathering information. You don't need to spend time to attempt this check, and there is no risk that you will be associated with your agents.

Last-Ditch Effort (Any Trait, Persistent): When you perform a risky operation while this persistent operation is in effect, you can gain a +2 bonus on the Operation check. If you do, you lose at least half of the agents you sent on the risky operation, even if it is successful. Beginning this operation requires a successful DC 17 Operation check.

Manufacturing (Any Trait): You can call on your agents' practical expertise to manufacture items on your behalf, allowing you to use the result of your Operation check in place of a craft skill check to create mundane items. You do not have to expend the time crafting, but your agents do, and you must still pay the raw materials cost for any items your agents manufacture.

Provide Distraction (Courage, Risky): Your agents may not be individually strong, but your example has inspired them, and they'd risk anything to help you, even in dangerous circumstances. At the beginning of combat near a populated area, roll an Operation check against a DC equal to 10 + the CR of the most challenging creature in the fight (maximum DC 25). On a success, each PC gains advantage on attack rolls or +2 to AC (PC's choice) for the first round of combat.

Recover Agents (Any Trait): If a risky operation goes awry, you may lose the agents you sent on the operation. Whenever you have fewer than the maximum number of agents your trait ranks would allow—that is, fewer than twice your total number of ranks in all traits combined—can launch an operation to rescue lost agents (or recruit new ones, if that flavor is preferred). To do so, you must attempt a DC 10 Operation check, using the trait of your choice. On a failed check,

you recovers one agent. On a successful check, you recovers two agents, plus one additional agent for every 5 by which the result exceeds the Operation check's DC.

Research (Smarts): Under your direction, your agents scour libraries for relevant information. You can use the result of your Operation check in place of a single Investigation/History/Religion check. Your agents must spend the required time, but this research takes none of your time.

Smuggle (Cleverness, Risky): Your agents smuggle a relatively small or innocuous object (such as a dagger or evidence to be used for blackmail) into a hiding place on someone else's property. The DC of the Operation check is equal to 10 + the CR of the captain or leader of any guards present.

Tend Wounds (Morals/Judgment, Persistent): Your agents help you tend to the injured, including you. If you succeed at a DC 17 Operation check, you receive one of the following benefits for the duration of the operation: either you and everyone in the tended community gain a +2 bonus on Constitution saves against disease, or you receive the benefits of long-term care whenever you rest for at least 8 hours in the area in which the operation is in effect.

Advanced Operations

You gain access to a trait's advanced operations when you have 6 Ranks in that trait.

Bad Advice (Smarts/Cleverness/Morals, Risky): You place agents among a target's advisors or messengers to feed him the information that will lead him to make wrong choices. At some point in this reputation round when your target must decide between two options, he must succeed at an Insight check opposed by your Operation check result or choose the option you favor or that benefits you.

Bolster Courage (Courage, Persistent): You send your agents to tell tales of your bravery, bolstering your own courage. If you succeed at a DC 17 Operation check, you receive advantage on saves against fear.

Guards (Courage/Morals, Risky): You are accompanied by a guard who watches your back, and agents in the field listen carefully for any potential dangers. If an opponent tries to ambush or sneak up on you, that character's Stealth check result must exceed both your Perception check result and the result of your Operation check to catch you unawares. On a failed Operation check, your enemies eliminate your guards before engaging you.

Invention (Smarts): Your agents help you create magic items and research spells. Select one spell or magic item. If you succeed at an Operation check, your agents find or create the chosen spell or item, and you can then purchase it for the standard cost. The DC of the Operation check is equal to 10 + caster level for a magic item, or 10 + twice the spell level for a spell.

Poison (Cleverness, Risky): Your agents slip a dose of poison or a potion (which you must pay for) into an NPC's food as it is being prepared and delivered. Attempt an Operation check with a DC equal to 10 + the CR of the target NPC or his highest level guard/adviser, whichever is highest. On a success, your agents deliver the substance without detection. The NPC attempts Constitution saves against the poison as normal.

Rumormonger (Any Trait, Persistent): Your agents improve your cover by spreading false rumors, destroying evidence, and intimidating anyone who asks too many questions. If you succeed at a DC 17 Operation check, anyone trying to see through a disguise or false identity you've assumed takes disadvantage on Perception and Insight skill checks to do so.

Safe Haven (Courage or Morals): Your agents find you a quiet place to rest in safe anonymity, usually somewhere out of the way such as a barn or cavern. Anyone trying to locate you must first succeed at an Investigation or Survival check opposed by your Operation check.

Sermonize (Morals, Persistent): Your agents spread your philosophical or religious beliefs. If you succeed at a DC 17 Operation check, you gain advantage on Persuasion and Intimidate checks against people who share your religion or philosophy, or who follow closely aligned practices, at the DM's discretion.

Spread Propaganda (Charm or Cleverness, Persistent): Your agents spread propaganda on your behalf. If you succeed at a DC 17 Operation check, you gain advantage on Deception and Disguise checks to either reinforce this same disinformation or deceive someone relying on it.

Actually, They're with Me (Charm or Cleverness, Risky): You place agents inside an enemy's forces. Once before your next reputation round, when you encounter a group of low-level, unnamed enemy agents, the total number of which can't exceed the number of agents you sent on this operation, compare the result of your Operation check against a DC of 15 or a DC of 10 + the Insight modifier of the agents' commander (whichever is higher). If you succeed, this "enemy" force is instead composed of the agents you placed earlier, allowing you to avoid combat and potentially resupply or rest. You can't use this operation to replace named NPCs.